the train stopped dead in the middle of a forest, we were told that there was a herd of wild elephants on the track; hence we could only restart our journey once they moved back into the jungle. Finally, we reached our destination – Dimapur – and the battalion detrained on a railway siding. We were piped in by pipes and drums of a sister battalion, and warmly welcomed by a reception committee from 81 Mountain Brigade. It was a huge effort to unload everything, specially the arms and ammunition and other controlled stores. After a thorough check, an 'OK report' was rendered by all the company commanders to the CO. Over the next few days, we were inducted by road into our area of responsibility in Phek, ahead of Kohima.

As the monsoon had already set in, the roads were in a big mess. There was only one major artery connecting Dimapur to Kohima and Imphal. Besides this highway, there were hardly any other black-topped roads in those days! Beyond Kohima it was a dirt track fit for vehicular traffic only in fair weather. In the event it had turned into a quagmire of slush. The wheels of the trucks had made ruts that were two feet deep at places. We had a few cases where the vehicles skidded off the road and fell down the hill. Fortunately, we had no casualties and were able to recover the vehicles as they were saved from going too far down the slope because of the dense forests. The battalion took over a week to settle down and the companies moved forward to their posts over the next ten days or so.

Since there was a ceasefire between Naga rebels and the government in force during that period, we had no armed encounters with the hostiles. There was an uneasy peace prevailing at that time, and seven rounds of talks had taken place between the Government of India and the underground 'Naga Federal Government'. Besides that, there was a peace mission established that was playing the role of a mediator. It had a peace centre and an observer team in Kohima. Dr Aram, a Sarvodaya worker, was one of its prominent members. Taking advantage of the ceasefire, we used to carry out a lot of patrolling to familiarize ourselves with the area of our operational responsibility. I was the intelligence officer (IO)